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It Wasn't Love. It Was Control.

Recognize the manipulation, trust yourself
again, and walk free.

START HERE

You're not crazy. You were being manipulated.

You keep replaying it, trying to figure out when the person who "loved" you became someone you walked on eggshells around. You doubt your own memory. You wonder if you're the problem. You miss them and you're terrified of them at the same time.

That confusion isn't a flaw in you — it's the *design* of the abuse. This is a clear-eyed guide to name what really happened, stop doubting your own reality, and find your way back to yourself.

FIRST, THE TRUTH

Love doesn't require you to shrink, apologize for existing, or lose yourself. What confused you was real manipulation — not your failure to "love them right."

STEP 1

Name what it actually was

Manipulation hides behind "love." Tick what you lived with — seeing it in a list is its own kind of clarity:

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Walking on eggshells around their moods | ☐ Controlling money, time, or your phone |
| ☐ Being made to doubt your own memory | ☐ Apologizing for things you didn't do |
| ☐ "You're too sensitive / crazy / dramatic" | ☐ Your "no" never being respected |
| ☐ Love-bombing, then cold withdrawal | ☐ The charming public face, different in private |
| ☐ Everything is somehow your fault | ☐ Constant criticism disguised as "help" |
| ☐ Cut off from friends & family | ☐ Feeling smaller than when you met them |

Several of these is not a rough patch. It's a pattern — and naming the pattern is how you stop blaming yourself for it.

STEP 2

The self-doubt was the point

Gaslighting works by making you distrust yourself, so you rely on *them* for what's "real."

Reclaim your reality:

- **Write it down.** Keep a private record of what's said and done. Your notes don't gaslight you.
- **Trust the pattern, not the apology.** What they *do* repeatedly is the truth, not what they say after.
- **Reconnect with reality-checkers.** The friends they pulled you away from saw clearly. Let them back in.
- **Your feelings are data.** If you felt small, scared, or confused — that happened. It counts.

"Am I overreacting?" is the question abuse trains you to ask. Start asking instead: "Would I accept this being done to someone I love?"

STEP 3

Cut the cord (and keep it cut)

They will try to pull you back — the apology, the "I've changed," the crisis, the charm. That's the hook. Hold the line:

- **No contact, if you safely can.** Block, mute, delete. No "closure" conversation — it's just another door in.
- **Gray rock if you can't go no-contact** (co-parenting): boring, brief, factual. Give them nothing to feed on.
- **Expect the "hoover."** The sudden sweetness or sob-story is a tactic to reel you back. Name it, don't answer it.
- **Remove the access.** Shared accounts, locations, passwords — quietly take your life back.

STEP 4

Why you still miss them

Here's the part that makes you feel insane: you got free, and you *miss* them. That's not weakness — it's a trauma bond, and it fades.

- **It's chemical, not proof you should go back.** The highs-and-lows cycle is literally addictive. Missing the high isn't love.
- **Grieve the person you thought they were** — not the one who hurt you. They're not the same.
- **Ride the urge out.** The pull to reach out peaks, then passes. Don't act on the wave.
- **Replace the bond.** Fill the space with safe people, routine, and small wins. Connection heals.

When I miss them, I'll remind myself:

YOU'RE FREE NOW

Come back to yourself.

Read these until you believe them again. They're true:

- What happened to me was real. I'm not "too sensitive."
- I am allowed to trust my own mind again.
- Missing them is not a reason to go back.
- Peace is not boring. It's what safety feels like.
- I am not who they said I was. I'm finding out who I really am.

Please read: if you are in danger, leaving an abuser can be the most dangerous time — please make a safety plan with help. In the U.S., the National Domestic Violence Hotline is **1-800-799-7233** (or text START to 88788), free and confidential, 24/7. You deserve support and safety.

You can see it clearly now. That's freedom.

The fog they put you in is lifting. Name it, trust yourself, hold the line. You were never the problem — and the woman they tried to make smaller is about to take up all the space she deserves.

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